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3.4 Bloody 1862

When a friend lets you down, you likely give him or her one more chance. But at a certain point, you get fed up. As Lincoln realized, you can give someone "just one more chance" only so many times.

MAIN IDEA The bloody battles of Antietam and Fredericksburg exacted a high cost from both Union and Confederate forces.

THE BLOODIEST DAY

You've read about the first Battle of Bull Run in 1861. A second battle took place there in 1862. After driving General George McClellan and his troops back to Washington, D.C., General Robert E. Lee marched his men northward to battle again at Bull Run outside Manassas, Virginia. On the third day of fighting, the Confederates forced the Union soldiers to retreat. Afterward, Lee went on the offensive and marched his troops north into Maryland. He wanted to move the war into the Union states.

President Lincoln called McClellan back into action and ordered him to defend the Union capital. On his way to meet Lee, McClellan got lucky. By chance, a Union soldier found a packet of cigars in a field, dropped by a careless Confederate officer. Wrapped around the cigars were Lee's detailed plans for the assault on Maryland. McClellan learned that Lee's forces were in two groups several miles apart. If McClellan moved quickly, he could destroy Lee's army before the groups joined up. But McClellan acted too late. The Confederate Army met Union soldiers on the battlefield at Antietam (an-TEE-tuhm) Creek near Sharpsburg, Maryland, on September 17.

The casualties for both sides at the **Battle of Antietam** numbered at least 23,000 men. The day of the battle would later be called "America's Bloodiest Day." The Union considered it a victory because Lee's forces left Maryland. But Lincoln was frustrated with McClellan's errors. He said, "If General McClellan does not want to use the army, I would like to borrow it for a time." The president named Ambrose Burnside as the new commander.

THE BATTLE OF FREDERICKSBURG

For his first campaign, General Burnside decided to lead his troops back toward Richmond to try to capture the Confederate capital. To reach Richmond, Burnside marched to Falmouth, near Fredericksburg, Virginia, where he planned to cross the Rappahannock River. The Union troops arrived at Falmouth in December 1862, but Lee's army had got there first and destroyed all the bridges. Burnside ordered army engineers to build floating bridges using **pontoons**, or hollow metal cylinders, but Confederate soldiers shot at the Union engineers while they worked.

Meanwhile, Lee and the rest of his troops dug into the hills above Fredericksburg and readied their artillery. When Burnside finally crossed the Rappahannock River, his forces fought for three days in an unsuccessful effort to take the hills. The Battle of Fredericksburg ended when Burnside retreated across the river.

After so many defeats, northern civilians were becoming restless. They did not like the turn the war had taken, and neither did Lincoln.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did McClellan discover Lee's plans at the Battle of Antietam?
2. **SUMMARIZE** How did these two battles reflect broader strategic patterns in the war?
3. **INTERPRET MAPS** Where were most of the Civil War battles fought, in the North or in the South? Explain why.

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